



God decides to
bring about the
existence of
contingent things

And this fact must be necessary, or contingent.

If it is necessary, then, again, premise (1) of our initial argument is false.

And if it is contingent, then by the PSR it must have some explanation. But what could this be?

This is a complex line of thought. Here's a different way to get at basically the same point.

It seems that for any two contingent facts, we can consider their
conjunction.

So, for example, if we start with the contingent facts

Notre Dame is in Indiana.

USC is in California.

We can also consider the conjunctive fact

Notre Dame is in Indiana and USC is in California.

It looks like we can also do this for arbitrarily long lists of contingent facts: 3 facts, 10 facts, 1 million facts, etc.

So now consider the the very big conjunctive fact C , which is the conjunction of all of the contingent facts that there are.

We know that C will be contingent. So, if the PSR is true, C has an explanation. Let's call this explanation "E."

Here's a plausible claim: no conjunctive facts can be explained by one of the facts that make it up. It would not make much sense to say that the reason why Notre Dame is in Indiana and USC is in California is that Notre Dame is in Indiana.

But C contains all of the contingent facts. So E must be necessary.

But here is another plausible claim: no necessary truth can ever explain a contingent truth. A necessary truth is something which is true no matter how the world turns out to be. So how could it explain some contingent fact about the world?

So we appear to have reached a contradiction. What is going on?

One way to think about the line of thought we have just pursued is that it shows that the PSR is inconsistent with the existence of contingent facts.

That would be terrible news for the cosmological argument, for that argument requires both the PSR and the premise that there are contingent things.

The view that there are no contingent facts is called **necessitarianism**.

Here's a way to make explicit the argument from PSR to necessitarianism
which we just rehearsed.

1. Every contingent fact has an explanation. (PSR)
 2. If there are contingent facts, then there is a conjunction C of all of the contingent facts.
 3. Any conjunction of contingent facts is contingent.
 4. If there are contingent facts, then C is explained by some fact E.
(1,2,3)
 5. No conjunctive fact can be explained by one of its conjuncts.
 6. If there are contingent facts, then C is explained by some necessary fact E. (4,5)
 7. No contingent fact can be explained by a necessary fact.
-

C. There are no contingent facts.
(6,7)

THE PSR $\rightarrow$ NECESSITARIANISM ARGUMENT

Any defender of the cosmological argument must deny that this argument is sound, since its conclusion rules out premise (1) of the cosmological argument.

But of course the
defender of the
cosmological argument
cannot reject the PSR.

So it looks like the defender of the cosmological argument either has to find a flaw in the logic of this argument, or reject one of its other independent premises.

Which looks like the best
option here?



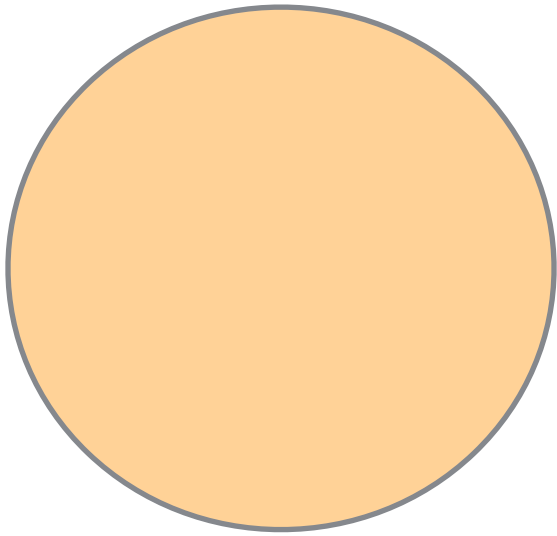
Leibniz's
argument



the
PSR



objections
to the
PSR



bring about the



Guides to

continuing things

existential

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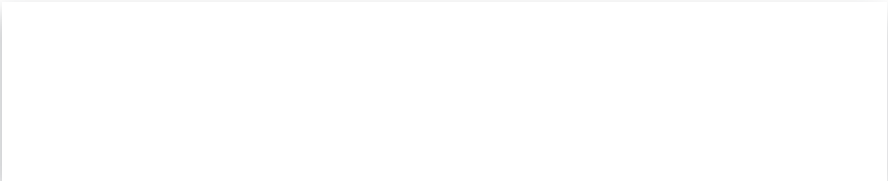
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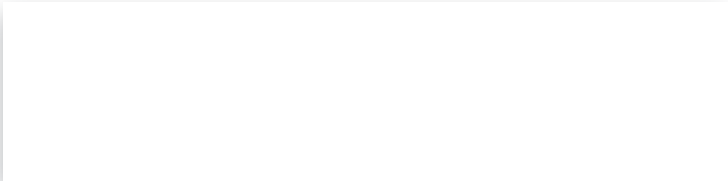
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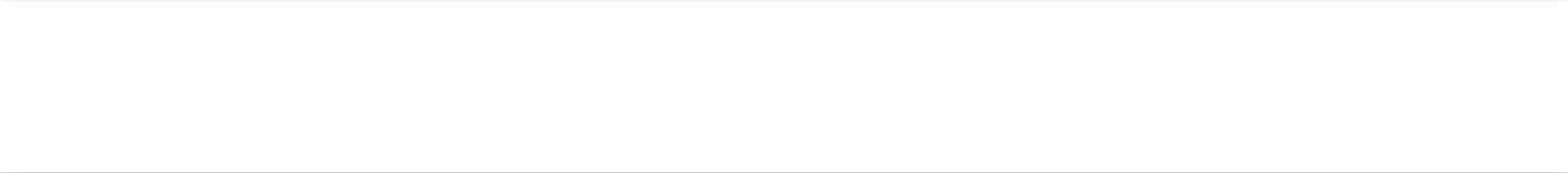


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(1, 2, 3)

C. There are no counting facts.

by a necessary fact.



explained by one of its constituents.

2. If there are *contingent* factors, then

exp1anation.(PSR)

there is a conjunction of all of



isn't it isn't it.

this counting gets facts.

1. Every contingent fact has an

4. If there are contingent facts, then

(6, 7)

7. Nothing is explained

C is explained by some fact E.

is at E. (4,5)

C is explained by some necessary

3. Any conjunction of constraints

5. No contraindications can be

6. If there are n independent factors, then



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Last time we considered an objection to Aquinas' assumption that if a first

simply be some event, like the Big Bang, which is not a plausible candidate to

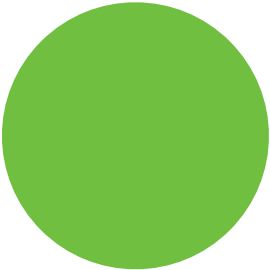
be Good.

cause exists, then God exists: the objection was that the first cause could



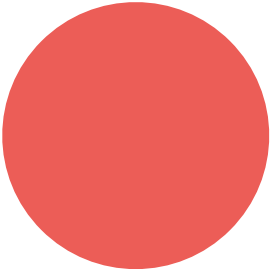
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... we cannot find in any of the individual things, or even in the entire collection and series of things, a sufficient reason for why they exist.

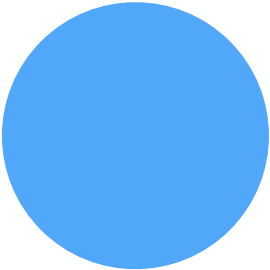
Let us suppose that a book on the elements of geometry has always existed, one copy always made from another. It is obvious that although we can explain a present copy of the book from the previous book from which it was copied, this will never lead us to a complete explanation, no matter how many books back we go, since we can always wonder why there have been such books.

What is true of these books is also true of the different states of the world ... however far back we might go into previous states, we will never find in those states a complete explanation for why there is a world at all, and why it is the way it is.





the
PSR





objections
to the
PSR





